as cautious. At the end of the day, the ROP would fall back and get together at a central place and then board a truck in order to avoid the walk back. One day, the LTTE targeted this truck itself, since the ROP was no longer effective, and caused many casualties. It was a big blow and a shock to all—it could easily have been us. Mixing a misplaced sense of welfare with operations had cost those jawans their lives, a lesson that stood me in good stead when I became a CO. After that, we were even more careful to not follow any pattern in our operations and never ever sat in the same position or under the same tree twice. After this incident, it was decided that we should be the ones doing the ROP right up to the Monkey Bridge. Since the major effort was now up front, the Company HQ also moved ahead to Villamkulam.

Life at Villamkulam was an experience in itself. The sanitation arrangement comprised a deep trench latrine (DTL) right next to the perimeter. When one DTL got filled up, another was dug up and small screens were put up to give a semblance of privacy. Being right next to the perimeter, there was every possibility of getting sniped at while doing the 'job'. Caught with your pants down, so to speak. Equally possible was for someone to have sneaked in and booby-trapped the DTL itself. Hence, as a matter of routine, the area of the DTL and up to 100 m beyond the perimeter was cleared every morning and everyone did his 'job', officers included, under the watchful eyes of the sentry seated atop the water tank. Sometimes, one or the other IEDs placed for early warning would go off with a loud bang, always at night. On hearing the loud explosion, we would all tumble out of our beds and run or crawl to the perimeter and man our 'stand-to' positions, the action stations. The LMG nearest the location would fire a few bursts of speculative fire in that general direction, even as we strained to see any signs of

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